New Kindergarten to Grade 6 (K-6) curriculum

Social studies

Overview

Social studies is the study of history, geography, economics, civics and citizenship, and government and politics. Students explore important questions and actively engage with issues to understand lessons from the past, and to become active and well-informed citizens in their communities. Students use a knowledge-based curriculum and combine social science methods, including research, source evaluation and evidence interpretation, to enhance understanding, draw conclusions and build robust critical-thinking skills.

New curriculum content update summary

What we heard

We considered feedback from multiple engagements and heard some common themes:

- Clear and concise: Clear and precise language is needed to support students with critical engagement with content.
- Load: Reduce content within some grades or learning outcomes.
- Developmental appropriateness: Some knowledge, understandings, and skills and procedures need to be better aligned with students' developmental level in a specific grade; more pre-requisite learning is needed in some grades to support the knowledge, understandings, and skills and procedures.
- First Nations, Métis and Inuit perspectives, contributions, and histories: Additional content is needed to support First Nations, Métis and Inuit perspectives; content needs to authentically represent First Nations, Métis and Inuit perspectives and contributions.
- Pluralism and francophone: Additional content is needed to support understanding of Alberta's diverse pluralistic society.

What we updated

We made the following content updates:

- Clear and concise: Language was clarified in learning outcomes and knowledge, understanding, and skills and procedures across K-6 to align with the Ministerial Order on Student Learning. These changes include limiting jargon and abstract language to ensure that the focus of learning is clear to students, parents, and teachers.
- Load: Changes include adjustments to the volume of content, resulting in increased emphasis on essential content. These adjustments increase opportunities for critical thinking. Changes in this category include removing duplications, consolidating content, and adding clarifying information where needed.
- Developmental appropriateness: Adjustments to content reflect stakeholder input on the extent to which students have the required background knowledge to meaningfully access essential learnings for each grade. Changes include adjusting sequencing/ordering of content and revising abstract concepts to be more tangible. In some cases, changes may include shifting verbs from passive to active voice. These changes ensure that concepts align with age and developmental readiness for critical thinking.
- First Nations, Métis and Inuit perspectives, contributions, and histories: Changes reflect revisions to support respectful and authentic inclusion of First Nations, Métis and Inuit histories, perspectives, and contributions.
- Pluralism and francophone perspectives, contributions, and histories: Changes also reflect respectful and authentic inclusion of pluralism and francophone histories, perspectives and contributions to support understanding of issues faced by society, such as discrimination and racism.

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Shifts in K-6 social studies curriculum

The following table shows how elements in the K-6 social studies curriculum, published in 2005, compare to the new 2025 curriculum. The comparisons provide examples and do not represent all the changes that were made.

	2005 curriculum	New curriculum (2025)
Disciplinary knowledge and skills consistently developed throughout all grades	History, geography, civics, economics, and other social studies-related disciplines are not addressed in each grade.	Content on history, geography, economics, politics, and citizenship is present in every grade.
Content on citizenship in all grades to support civic engagement	The inclusion of civics varies by grade.	Citizenship is an organizing idea across all grades.
Respectful and authentic inclusion of First Nations, Métis and Inuit perspectives	Limited inclusion of authentic and respectful First Nations, Métis and Inuit perspectives in some grades.	First Nations, Métis and Inuit histories, contributions, and perspectives are included authentically and respectfully.
Inclusion of pluralism and diverse perspectives	Opportunities to support pluralism and learn about diverse people and communities vary from grade to grade.	Pluralism is included in all grades as learners explore cultural diversity in the community, across Canada, and throughout the world.

Snapshots by grade

In social studies, students learn about geography, history, economics, politics, and citizenship. The snapshots provide an overview of some of the content that students explore in each grade.

Kindergarten: Culture, tradition, and community

- places in communities
- cultures, traditions, and histories
- needs and wants
- leaders in communities
- cooperation and collaboration in groups

Grade 1: Local communities and cultures

- key physical features and landmarks of communities
- cultures of diverse communities, including First Nations, Métis, Inuit, and francophone communities
- exchange of goods and services
- roles and responsibilities in groups
- supporting belonging
- Canada’s official symbols

Grade 2: Canada – Communities and heritage

- Canada’s physical regions and natural resources
- leaders in Canada, including the prime minister and the premiers
- traditions and heritages across Canada, including those of First Nations, Métis, Inuit, francophones, and diverse communities
- ways trade and transportation support communities
- competencies for democratic discussion and decision making

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Grade 3: Alberta and the prairies

- physical regions and political boundaries of Alberta
- First Nations and Métis contributions to Alberta
- francophone settlement and contributions to Alberta
- introduction to discrimination and racism in Alberta
- provincial and municipal governments
- Alberta's official symbols
- Alberta's natural resources
- charitable giving and volunteerism

Grade 4: Colonial Canada and Confederation

- changes in power and influence in pre-Confederation Canada
- Jacques Cartier and early settlements
- Samuel de Champlain and the establishment of Quebec City and New France
- the Treaty of Paris and the transfer of Canada to the British
- the United Empire Loyalists
- the Rebellions of 1837, responsible government, and Confederation
- the fur trade and Canada's natural resources
- citizenship rights and responsibilities

Grade 5: Ancient civilizations

- the rise and fall of ancient civilizations
- influence of the environment on ancient civilizations
- development of economic practices, including trade networks and taxes
- authoritarian governments and social systems
- legacies of ancient civilizations and empires
- informed citizenship

Grade 6: Democracy – History, principles, and operation

- principles of democracy
- ancient Athenian direct democracy
- Roman Republic representative democracy
- Haudenosaunee Confederacy decision making
- provincial and federal governments in Canada
- the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms
- formal and informal civic participation
- discrimination and racism

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